



UPMUNC 58

University of Pennsylvania Model United Nations Conference | November 13-16, 2025

2024 Standing Committee of the Chinese Communist Party



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LETTER FROM THE CHAIR

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to UPMUNC 58! I'm Lisel Ndrecka and I'll be your chair for this Crisis on the 2019 Standing Committee of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). On behalf of me and your staffers, I would like to express how excited we are to welcome you to the conference!

Unlike your ordinary crisis topic, this committee will place you at the very center of the CCP's most powerful decision-making body during a moment of extraordinary uncertainty post-Covid. As delegates, you will be tasked with navigating high-stakes questions of governance, political legitimacy, and China's future path in the face of internal and external pressures. The issues before you will range from corruption and economic instability to factional rivalries and the possibility of foreign involvement. We encourage you to think beyond the immediate challenges and ask whether or not it is worth it to preserve stability, maintain your power, or instill reform. Cindy and I are excited to see how you work as a team, and, of course, as a party.

A bit about me: I'm currently a senior in the College of Arts and Sciences studying Economics and data analytics. On campus, I am also involved in INTERCOL, Penn's Model UN team, and many of you may recognize me as last year's Chief of Staff of UPMUNC. Outside of campus, you'll likely find me running on various city paths around Philadelphia, volunteering, and travelling.

I love my home-city of Philadelphia (go Birds) and have grown to love Penn (go Quakers) so I'm incredibly excited to extend a warm welcome to you all for my last UPMUNC. Please feel free to email me, Cindy, or any of your staffers regarding questions about committee. We look forward to seeing you in November!

Lisel Ndrecka

Chair

2024 Standing Committee of the CCP | UPMUNC 58

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LETTER FROM THE CRISIS DIRECTOR

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to UPMUNC LVIII! My name is Cindy and I have the honour of serving as your chair for the 2024 Standing Committee of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). On behalf of myself and our entire staff, I want to extend our excitement as we prepare to embark on a weekend of high-stakes debate, creative problem-solving, and political maneuvering.

This committee will place you inside the CCP's most powerful decision-making body at a time of immense uncertainty. It is 2024, the Covid-19 pandemic lies behind us, and yet China faces new waves of instability. The nation is wrestling with a collapsing housing market, mounting debt, and questions about the sustainability of its economic model. At the same time, Xi Jinping's ongoing purge of political rivals has heightened internal rivalries, while whispers of corruption and foreign influence test the Party's unity. This crisis will test your ability to step into complex characters with layered motives and hidden pasts. Who are you really? What drives your decisions, what secrets do you carry, and what do you know about those around you? The answers, delegates, are entirely in your hands.

Going on to a little bit about me, I'm a sophomore in the College of Arts and Sciences originally from Australia, studying Economics and Urban Studies. I'm involved in INTERCOL, the University of Pennsylvania's collegiate Model UN team. Beyond MUN, I like (attempting to) paint and do arts and crafts. I'm an avid skier and love spending time outdoors going to the beach or embarking on a hike. I'm also big on exploring, whether that's traveling or finding the best coffee spots in Philly!

If you have any questions about the committee or the background guide, please don't hesitate to reach out to me or Lisel at any time. We're excited to see how you bring your characters to life this November!

Cindy Chen
Crisis Director
2024 Standing Committee of the CCP | UPMUNC 58
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1

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) committee! In this simulation, you will step into the role of CCP leaders navigating a crisis room focused on China's most pressing economic, social, and political challenges. The committee is set in 2024, following the Covid-19 pandemic, and will remain within this year for the entirety of the session. This timeframe allows us to explore the most urgent and topical issues that emerged in the post-Covid period.

While some topics may involve ongoing political sensitivities, all members are encouraged to approach them with respect, while maintaining the creative and strategic spirit of a crisis committee.

As representatives of the CCP, you will work collectively to address domestic challenges as they arise, while also managing international pressures, events, and conflicts. Collaboration is essential—work together as a team, and above all else, put the party first.

2

STANDING COMMITTEE OF THE POLIBURO

a. Origins and History

The Chinese Communist Party (CCP) was founded in 1921 in Shanghai by a small group of intellectuals inspired by Marxism and the success of the 1917 Russian Revolution.¹ At the time, China was deeply unstable: the Qing dynasty had collapsed in 1911, the country was divided among competing warlords, and foreign powers controlled large parts of its economy and territory.² The CCP's early mission was to build a strong, unified China free from foreign domination and social inequality. In its early years, the CCP worked alongside the Nationalist Party (Kuomintang, or KMT), but the alliance quickly broke down. In 1927, KMT leader Chiang Kai-shek

launched a violent purge of Communists in Shanghai, killing thousands and forcing the Party underground. Surviving CCP members fled to the countryside, where they began organizing peasants and experimenting with new models of land redistribution and governance.

A defining moment came with the Long March (1934–1935)³, a year-long retreat of Red Army forces over thousands of miles to escape encirclement by Nationalist troops. Though devastating with only a fraction of the marchers surviving, the march became the enduring symbol of Communist endurance. During this period, Mao Zedong rose to prominence as the Party's leader, laying the foundation for his decades-long dominance of Chinese politics.

During World War II, the CCP fought both Japanese invaders and its Nationalist rivals. By the end of the war in 1945, the CCP had expanded its control over rural China and gained credibility for resisting Japan. When the civil war with the KMT resumed⁴, the Communists gradually won popular support, especially among peasants, and built a disciplined military force. In 1949, the CCP defeated the Nationalists, who retreated to Taiwan, and Mao declared the founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC) in Beijing.⁵

Following the establishment of the People's Republic of China in 1949, the CCP needed a system to consolidate and exercise control over the vast new state. To manage this, it developed a layered leadership structure based on Soviet models. At the top of this hierarchy sat the Politburo, a body of about two dozen senior officials who directed Party policy. Within the Politburo, an even smaller inner circle was created: the Standing Committee of the Politburo, often called the Standing Committee for short.

The Standing Committee was designed to act as the CCP's supreme decision-making body. Composed of just a handful of the Party's most powerful figures, it functioned as the leadership core of both the CCP and the Chinese state. While government institutions such as the presidency, the State Council, and the National People's Congress were created to administer laws and policies, real authority always rested with the Standing Committee.

1 <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Chinese-Communist-Party>
2 <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Qing-dynasty>

3 <https://www.britannica.com/event/Long-March>
4 <https://www.britannica.com/event/Chinese-Civil-War>
5 <https://www.britannica.com/biography/Mao-Zedong>

Under Mao Zedong (1949–1976), however, the Standing Committee’s formal role was often overshadowed by Mao’s personal dominance. Mao used his revolutionary prestige to dictate policy directly, especially during mass campaigns like the Great Leap Forward (1958–1962) and the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976). During these years, the Standing Committee still existed, but it functioned less as a collective leadership body and more as a stage for Mao’s ideological struggles, with members frequently purged or sidelined depending on their loyalty.

After Mao’s death in 1976, the Party leadership sought to prevent the chaos of unchecked personal rule from repeating. Deng Xiaoping and his successors strengthened the Standing Committee as an institution, emphasizing collective leadership and internal balance among Party elites. From the 1980s onward, the Standing Committee became the undisputed center of power in China, with its small group of members shaping the country’s domestic and foreign policy direction.

b. Membership and Mechanics

The Standing Committee of the Politburo is the highest decision-making body in China, sitting at the top of both the Communist Party and the state hierarchy. Although the Chinese state has a president, premier, and legislature, these positions are ultimately secondary. The Standing Committee is where real power lies, and its decisions shape every aspect of Chinese governance.



The Standing Committee usually consists of five to eleven members⁶, depending on the era. During Mao Zedong’s rule, its size fluctuated, sometimes expanding dramatically during the upheavals of the Cultural Revolution before

being reduced again. In the modern era, the Committee has generally stabilized at around seven members. Membership is not determined by public elections but instead through a secretive process within the CCP. Officially, the Party’s Central Committee “elects” the Politburo, and the Politburo then “elects” the Standing Committee. In practice, however, these results are the product of behind-the-scenes negotiation, factional compromise, and the influence of the top leader.⁷

Members of the Standing Committee are typically drawn from the Party’s most senior officials. Many have served as provincial Party secretaries, heads of ministries, or leaders of state-owned enterprises. They often represent different factions or interest groups within the CCP, such as loyalists to the General Secretary, technocrats focused on economic modernization, or conservatives emphasizing ideology and Party discipline. This composition ensures that the Standing Committee reflects both a concentration of power and a balance of competing political currents inside the CCP.

Each member of the Standing Committee is generally assigned a portfolio of responsibilities, which helps divide the vast tasks of governing China. The General Secretary of the CCP, currently Xi Jinping, serves as the top leader and dominates decision-making. The Premier is typically tasked with overseeing economic policy and managing the day-to-day operations of government. Other members may be responsible for areas such as internal security, propaganda and ideology, foreign policy, or Party discipline. While the Committee officially operates on a principle of collective leadership, in practice the General Secretary sets the agenda and carries the greatest influence.⁸

The Committee functions through closed-door meetings held regularly in Beijing’s Zhongnanhai leadership compound. These discussions are never made public, and meeting minutes are not released. To the outside world, decisions are always presented as unanimous, even when debates and disagreements take place behind the scenes. This secrecy is deliberate, designed to reinforce the Party’s image of unity and to prevent political rivalries from spilling into the public domain.

⁶ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Politburo_Standing_Committee_of_the_Chinese_Communist_Party#:~:text=Historically%20it%20has%20been%20composed,body%2C%20is%20not%20in%20session.

⁷ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Politburo_of_the_Chinese_Communist_Party

⁸ <https://chinaopensourceobservatory.org/glossary/pbsc>

At the top of the Party hierarchy, the Standing Committee sits above the wider Politburo, which consists of around 25 senior leaders, and the Central Committee, which has about 200 full members and meets once a year. This tiered structure allows the CCP to manage its vast bureaucracy while ensuring that real power remains concentrated in the hands of a very small group of individuals. Through this structure, the Standing Committee continues to dominate Chinese politics as the ultimate authority in the world's most populous nation.

3

THE ECONOMIC RISE OF CHINA

a. Reform and Opening Up

During the period of Mao Zedong's rule, protectionism and state economic planning ruled China's institutions. Mao's effort to instill a "Cultural Revolution" throughout the country in 1966 led to severe consequences for the country. During this time, freedom was limited, enemies of the state were persecuted, and private property was outlawed. This era of state monopolization ended with his death in September 1976 and opened the door for a new wave of reforms. Deng Xiaoping came to power in 1978 after a meeting with the Third Plenum of the Eleventh Central Committee of the CCP. Deng and his leadership launched these market reforms to open China's economy to the rest of the world. This period, also known as the Boluan Fanzheng period, was a reversal of the effects in the Cultural Revolution. Now the focus was on the "Four Modernizations," particularly industry, agriculture, science, and defense. Unlike the limitations under state-led development, China's economy grew through a market-oriented system. The CCP shifted its focus from class struggle to economic development. These reforms included the household responsibility system, township and village enterprise (TVEs), establishment of economic zones (SEZs), and paved the way for modern day developments, such as joining the WTO. Deng allowed for markets to flourish by reinstating property rights and global trade. While Mao's policies barred the flourishing of productivity, human capital, and entrepreneurship, Deng's leadership offered a new wave of economic prosperity under an open, free market model, to which he famously

has stated, "It doesn't matter whether the cat is black or white; if it catches mice, it's a good cat." Although critics still point to weaknesses in the CCP's constant monopoly on power and the regression of Deng's policies under Xi Jinping's rule.

b. Tiananmen Square Massacre

Despite this period of economic growth, there were large pro-democracy protests starting from the spring of 1989. The catalyst for these demonstrations was the death of Hu Yaobang, former General Secretary of the Communist Party who was a well-known reformer that was ousted from his position by other political opponents. He became a martyr towards a growing call for anti-corruption in government. These protests began on April 17th, 1989 when tens of thousands of university students gathered in the central area of Beijing: Tiananmen Square. Students protested several causes including high price inflation, corruption by government officials, freedom of speech, and less censorship. These demonstrations began to spread to other cities around the country including Shanghai, Nanjing, and Xi'an. The initial response by the Chinese government was moderate, including warnings and alerts, although this soon escalated. The faction of the CCP that called for greater control asserted forcibly suppressing the protests, including Chinese premier Li Peng and statesmen Deng Xiaoping. By the time Mikhail Gorbachev arrived in Beijing for the Sino-Soviet summit on May 15th, thousands of students were on a hunger strike and continuing to block major streets in the city. Near the end of May, Li Peng declares martial law in Beijing and sends the People's Liberation Army Troops (PLA) to occupy the city. These forces are met peacefully by protestors, who are able to deescalate these troops and eventually lead to the PLA's leave. After this unsuccessful



attempt by the government to curb protests, an estimated 200,000-300,000 armed troops are called upon to enter Beijing and open fire. The government's estimated count on June 3-4th was 241 casualties, including soldiers, although the Chinese Red Cross initially reported 2,600 before government pressure forced the removal of this number. To this day, the events of Tiananmen Square are heavily censored by the Chinese government and the number of actual deaths is still unknown. President George W. Bush enacted sanctions and denounced the massacre of Tiananmen Square.

c. Continued Economic Growth (1990-2010)

Before this event, the West predicted that, "when China...integrated into the global economy it would create a middle class that demanded democracy...but that did not happen," explains exiled human rights lawyer Teng Biao. After the Tiananmen Square massacre, the CCP did not collapse but instead reasserted their control through tactics like censorship and restricting political liberalization. The CCP continued its goal of opening China to foreign investment and economic zones while simultaneously promoting Chinese nationalism. Jiang Zemin became the general secretary of the CCP from 1989 to 2002 and was succeeded by Hu Jintao, who guided China's entry into the World Trade Organization. The period of Hu's rule from 2002 to 2012 was categorized by increased economic growth but equally high corruption, inequality, and one-party rule. This paved the way for Xi Jinping to come into government and has since consolidated more power than any leader since Mao Zedong.

4

THE RISE OF XI

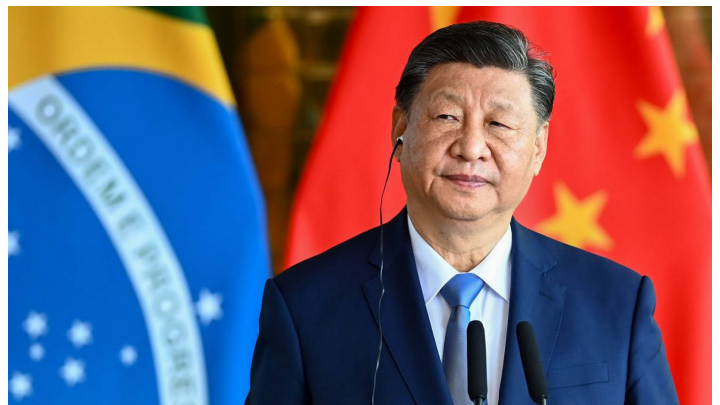
Xi Jinping grew up under Mao Zedong's rule. His father, Xi Zhongxun, a revolutionary veteran, was purged and imprisoned during Mao's campaigns and subjected to periods of hard labor. During the Cultural Revolution, Xi himself was sent to the countryside, where he endured years of manual labor and hardship. Despite these experiences, Xi came to admire aspects of Mao's governing style, later drawing on Maoist methods such as centralizing authority, controlling ideology, and launching mass political campaigns.

a. The CCP Under Xi's Rule

Since Xi Jinping assumed leadership in 2012, the CCP has centralized its power around him. During his rule he abolished presidential term limits and instilled his "Xi Jinping Thought" into both the party constitution and educational curricula. In regards to corruption, Xi asserts his method of "killing tigers and swatting flies" particularly in the CCP. Corruption at all levels including high-ranking government officials or lower-level bureaucrats will be targeted. In fact this was one of the key highlights in his first speech as General Secretary of the CCP. Under Xi, the CCP has tightened its grip on all facets of Chinese life—expanding censorship, enforcing ideological discipline, and increasing surveillance through digital technologies. One of his loyalty tactics included purges and reforms to ensure the People's Liberation Army pledged allegiance to the Party rather than the state. This power extends to the types of businesses that have provided economic prosperity to the country, with Xi pushing private firms—particularly technology firms—to align their strategies with national priorities.

b. Xi's Main Goals and Foreign Policy

Xi Jinping's domestic agenda is one centered around the notion of "common prosperity," which should reduce inequality and create a fairer distribution of wealth. His goals under the 14th Five-Year Plan (2021-2025) include narrowing consumption gaps while encouraging innova-



tion and growth among both public and private sectors. However, the domestic economy in recent years has faced challenges, including slowing economic growth, an aging population, and surmounting debt that has reached a debt to GDP ratio of 288%. His economic approach is one centered around self-reliance, particularly in the technology sector, and increasing global dominance in industries such as artificial intelligence and semiconduc-

tors. By prioritizing domestic innovation and reducing dependence on foreign technology, Xi aims to put China's global competitiveness at the forefront and secure strategic independence.

c. Belt and Road Initiative

China's Foreign Policy during the leadership of Xi Jinping has been characterized by heightened chauvinism, globalist rhetoric, and apparent incoherence. However, the one thing tying Chinese foreign policy together is the fact that Xi and the Communist elite believe that, due to inescapable Marxist rules of history, the US will eventually decline and China will become the unchallenged world

一带一路经济走廊及其途经城市分布图



power. To this effect, Xi abandoned the more conciliatory approach of his predecessors in exchange for a much more aggressive and confrontational approach.

A core part of this approach is the “Belt and Road Initiative” (BRI), which seeks to commission infrastructure projects along a trading route that roughly resembles China's historical Silk Road. The BRI is not a single program but rather a government-created slogan for a wide range of ad-hoc Chinese investments. Usually, a deal is first negotiated between the Chinese and the host governments, after which the host nation borrows money from a Chinese bank. This money is subsequently used to hire a Chinese construction company, which uses its own employees to complete the project. Over 1 trillion dollars have already been invested through BRI, mostly into Southeast Asia, Central Asia, and Africa.

Despite being mostly targeted towards domestic audiences, the BRI has had a mostly negative image outside of China. Many consider the BRI to be a form of “debt

slavery”, due to the high interest rates charged. For comparison, the World Bank's average interest rate is 1.56%, while the BRI's is 5%, with rates reaching 10% in some African countries. Opponents argue that this causes these countries to be unable to pay off these debts, which leads them to dependency on China. These countries have no choice but to turn over natural resources and government contracts as payment, while also supporting China diplomatically, boosting Chinese soft power. The United States and Western institutions, such as the OECD, have extensively criticized the BRI and its subsidiary programs, viewing them as a form of Chinese imperialism.

5

THE NEW COLD WAR

a. US-China Hostility

Since 2016, China and the United States have resumed their rivalry, which has been quietly paused since the days of Mao. The hostility between the United States and China has traditionally been based on one thing: Taiwan. In the 50's and 60's, the US supported the rights and sovereignty of the Republic of China's Government in exile on Taiwan, not Mao's PRC on the mainland. Historically, US support of Taiwan has irked the Chinese, which gives context to new hostility in the Trump-Biden period. Additionally, competition between the two powers has been trade-based, signaling a shift from the Cold War's war of words to a trade-war.

In the first months of the Trump Presidency, many critiqued China's militarization of the South China Sea, which included military exercises and missile installations extremely close to Taiwan. In response to this, the US sent nearly \$1.5 billion in arms to Taiwan, including anti-radiation missiles and torpedoes, causing more unrest in China. One year later, the Congress passed the Taiwan Travel Act, building on the 1979 Taiwan Relations Act, encouraging high-level diplomatic exchanges between the US and Taiwan, which China condemned as a violation of sovereignty. The important thing to note about US-China hostilities in relation to Taiwan is that they can best be described as a back-and-forth, a display of brinkmanship.

In 2019, US naval operations shored up defenses in the Taiwan Strait, which prompted China to step up air control in the zone. Later, when Nancy Pelosi visited Taiwan in August 2022 under President Biden, China issued the largest PLA Military exercise ever conducted near Taiwan. When Chinese PLA flights into Taiwan's Air Defense Identification Zone (ADIZ) reached record levels, the US shored up partnerships with the Philippines and Japan. Signing the U.S.–Philippines Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement (EDCA), they conducted joint “Balikatan” exercises with the Philippines near Taiwan. On the issue of Taiwan, US-China hostilities have cascaded in the last 8 years, less as a series of repeated confrontations, and more as isolated actions in reaction to each other.

The other dimension of US-China hostilities is in trade, especially in light of the BRI's globalization of the Chinese economy and development of an export economy under Zhou Enlai and Hu Jintao. At the same time, this came in conflict with the US's growing individualist mindset and the need to flex its economic muscle against the rest of the world. Under Trump, who came in with a confrontational attitude, the U.S. launched investigations into China's trade practices, accusing them of unfair subsidies and IP theft. On top of these allegations, the Trump presidency brought the onset of an extremely popular tool in the Modern Cold War Era: Tariffs. 2018-2019 brought a tariff-trade war with US tariffs, and China retaliated with tariffs on politically relevant items like corn, soybeans, and pork.

Beyond the Tariff War in 2018-2019, hostilities arose over trade inequities and spheres of global dominance. The US placed bans and export controls on Chinese firms like ZTE and Huawei, leading to limited access to advanced semiconductors and AI tech. President Biden continued the expansion of hostility, with the CHIPS and Science Act aiming to bring semiconductor production to the US, and away from the traditional dominator of the space, China. On the other hand, China responded to US hostility with its own aggravation. By strengthening their “Made in China” initiative, the state led a plan to make China self-sufficient and dominant in green tech, robotics, and aerospace. Inherently, Washington viewed this action as mercantilist and protectionist, which led to more tension. With China's Unreliable Entity list of blacklisted US companies threatening Chinese security, they further inflamed tensions, prompting the US to adopt a much

more aggressive anti-China trade policy.

All in all, the tensions between the US and China have primarily been two pronged, related to Trade, but also Taiwan. On an implicit level, these issues are intertwined, and actions taken in one arena impacts the other. When the passes a law protecting Taiwanese semiconductor assets, China feels it is a national security and trade issue, prompting their own action. The two parties are locked in a deadlock, with each action the other takes leading both down the path of no return. Going forward, China and the US will have to adopt a policy of increased brinksmanship to avoid further tensions and a possible armed conflict that will have global implications.

b. Donald Trump (2016-2020)

Under Donald Trump, the US-China relationship changed from one of cautious cooperation to one of open competition. Trump ran on a platform of claiming that China had been exploiting the US for decades and that US trade agreements were unfair. He accused Beijing of developing its economy at the expense of the United States while stealing American jobs and intellectual property. The first battlefield was trade. The so-called trade war began in 2018 when Trump levied \$34 billion in tariffs on Chinese goods. China targeted Trump's rural support base with tariffs on American agricultural products in retaliation. Through several rounds of tariff increases, the conflict intensified until the US levied duties on Chinese imports valued at almost \$370 billion.

Trump's strategy extended beyond trade disputes. Instead of viewing China as a possible ally, his administration started to view it as a strategic adversary. China was specifically identified as America's top long-term rival in the Pentagon's 2018 National Defense Strategy. As American freedom of navigation patrols and Chinese island-building projects collided in the South China Sea, military tensions increased. Another front in the competition was technology. The Trump administration claimed that Chinese tech companies were a threat to national security. It puts Huawei on the Entity List in 2019, severing the company's access to American technology and suppliers. The action was taken to stop China from controlling 5G networks around the world and possibly obtaining access to private data.

The Covid-19 pandemic further exacerbated tensions. In public remarks, Trump referred to the virus as the 'China virus' and blamed China for its spread. He said the US was too influenced by Beijing and withdrew from the World Health Organization. Global supply chains were upset by the pandemic, and American worries about reliance on Chinese manufacturing were reaffirmed.

The relationship had deteriorated to its lowest level in decades by the end of Trump's presidency. His government strengthened military ties with Taiwan, closed Chinese consulates, and sanctioned officials in Xinjiang and Hong Kong. Both countries saw a dramatic decline in public opinion, with surveys indicating that most people saw the other country as a threat.

c. Joe Biden (2021-2024)

When he took office, Joe Biden pledged to mend fences and make foreign policy more consistent, but he largely maintained Trump's tough stance on China. Biden characterized the relationship as 'strategic competition' and presented the rivalry as a global struggle between democracy and authoritarianism.

Under Biden, trade tensions continued. Biden maintained the majority of Trump's tariffs despite criticizing them as being badly thought out. By tightening export restrictions on semiconductors and other cutting-edge technologies, his administration continued to prioritize safeguarding American technology against Chinese competition. To lessen reliance on Asian suppliers, the CHIPS Act of 2022 allocated \$52 billion for domestic semiconductor manufacturing.

In addition, Taiwan turned into a major hot spot. Biden made multiple claims that the United States would use force to defend Taiwan in the event of a Chinese attack, even though he upheld the long-standing 'One China' policy. His staff later provided clarification on these remarks, which signaled a break from decades of strategic ambiguity. Following House Speaker Nancy Pelosi's visit to Taiwan in August 2022, China conducted extensive military drills around the island which escalated military tensions in the region.

With the start of the war in Ukraine, tensions between the US and China got even worse. Biden warned the Chinese leaders against giving Moscow military support and

instead urged them to help economically isolate Russia. The United States had previously held the perception that the Chinese and Russians were opposed to the democratic global order. But this opinion was strengthened when China announced their alliance with Russia shortly before the invasion.

Furthermore, their economic and military rivalry worsened across the board. Biden issued executive orders that prohibited American investment in Chinese military-affiliated firms and limiting Chinese investment in sensitive US industries. In keeping with Trump's policies, the administration also tightened its scrutiny on Chinese researchers and students attending American universities. And that relationship was not improving by 2024. There are frequent military incidents in the South China Sea and both nations are boosting their defense budgets in preparation for conflict. America even strengthened its security ties with Japan, South Korea, Australia and India through a variety of alliance structures. And, in response, China increased the size of its nuclear arsenal.

The declining relationship was reflected in public polling in both countries. According to Pew Research, more than 80% of Americans have a negative opinion of China which is a historically low number. Similar anti-American sentiment was evident on Chinese social media where official government accounts promoted stories about China's rise and the United States' decline.

Over the course of Biden's presidency, the competition grew to include technology, space, and global governance in addition to the conventional military and economic domains. Both nations aimed to sway international organizations and norms to their advantage. While America sought to counter Chinese influence through its own infrastructure programs, China marketed its Belt and Road Initiative as an alternative to development models led by the West.

One can only hope that the relationship between America and China will improve soon.

6

CONCLUSIONS

As members of the CCP, you are the central decision-making body of China. The combined power of this group derives from the Party as well as the Standing Committee of the Politburo. Your role is to navigate China's challenges as CCP leaders, balancing power, policy, and public perception while advancing the Party's objectives. Consider where you stand within the Party hierarchy, how to leverage your authority and connections, and how historical lessons can inform your decisions.

The delegates should consider these topics to be of the utmost importance to the Central Committee of the Politburo of the Chinese Communist Party:

1. Strengthening the Belt and Road Initiative's Global Legitimacy
2. Strengthening Party Ideological Control
3. Energy Security and Green Transition
4. Military Modernization and Projection
5. Managing Relations with Global Powers

While China faces many domestic and international challenges, consider how your decisions will impact the Party and the future of the nation. The CCP's guiding principles have been economic growth, social stability, and equity among resources. Keep these foundational goals in mind as you are challenged with crises that test the Party's strength. Collaboration and coordination within the Party are essential—work together, maintain discipline, and put the Party above individual ambitions.

7

CHARACTERS

I. Xi Loyalists

Xi Jinping – General Secretary, President, CMC Chairman

Xi Jinping is the paramount leader of China, holding the country's top political, state, and military titles. The son of a revolutionary veteran, Xi lived through both privilege

and hardship during the Cultural Revolution, experiences that hardened his belief in Party control. Since 2012, he has centralized power to a degree unseen since Mao, scraping term limits, sidelining rivals, and embedding “Xi Jinping Thought” into the constitution. His leadership has been marked by sweeping anti-corruption purges and an increasingly authoritarian style, though critics allege he has stifled innovation and created dangerous bottlenecks of power at the top.

Li Qiang – Premier

Li Qiang rose through Zhejiang province under Xi's mentorship, gaining his trust during the early 2000s. As Shanghai Party Secretary, Li gained notoriety for enforcing harsh COVID-19 lockdowns, sparking widespread anger, but his loyalty to Xi ensured his promotion to Premier in 2023. In theory China's number two, Li has less authority than past premiers, with the State Council increasingly subordinated to Party organs. Though considered pragmatic, he is criticized as lacking independence, tied closely to Xi's fortunes and facing skepticism over his economic credentials.

Cai Qi – PSC member, Propaganda Chief

Cai Qi built his career in Zhejiang under Xi and later served as Beijing Party Secretary, overseeing the capital during the 2022 Winter Olympics. Elevated to the Politburo Standing Committee, he now manages the CCP's General Office, giving him broad control over Party operations and propaganda. Known for blunt loyalty, Cai has been described as one of Xi's most zealous defenders, enforcing ideological conformity and surveillance in Beijing. His rise was unusually rapid, prompting whispers that his success comes less from talent than proximity to Xi.

Ding Xuexiang – PSC member, Executive Vice Premier

Ding Xuexiang is Xi Jinping's longtime aide, having worked directly under him since Shanghai. Now a member of the Politburo Standing Committee, he serves as Executive Vice Premier, wielding power both in economic management and as Xi's chief gatekeeper. Ding is known for his discretion and discipline, rarely taking the spotlight but controlling access to Xi and shaping how directives are implemented. Some in the Party grumble that his career rests entirely on Xi's patronage rather than his own achievements, making him resented by peers.

Chen Min'er – Party Secretary of Tianjin

Chen Min'er is one of Xi's protégés, known for his loyalty and effectiveness in advancing central initiatives. He worked under Xi in Zhejiang and later gained national prominence as Party Secretary of Guizhou, where he implemented poverty reduction campaigns. In 2017 he was promoted to lead Chongqing after a corruption purge, signaling Xi's deep trust. Now Party Secretary of Tianjin, he is seen as a possible future successor, though his exclusion from the Standing Committee in 2022 was taken as a setback. Critics note that his rise is closely tied to Xi's fortunes, making him vulnerable if the leadership weakens.

Liu He

Liu He was a Vice Premier and is a key economic advisor to Xi Jinping, deeply involved in shaping China's macroeconomic policy, trade negotiations, and financial reforms. A trained economist with experience in both government and academia, Liu has been praised for his technocratic expertise and ability to navigate complex international economic environments. Critics, however, argue that his influence is constrained by political factionalism and the limits of technocratic authority under Xi. Nevertheless, his prominence in economic policy-making gives him significant sway over China's development priorities and global trade strategy.

Zhang Youxia

Zhang Youxia is Vice Chairman of the Central Military Commission and a senior leader in the People's Liberation Army, with a long career in both field command and military administration. Known for his loyalty to Xi Jinping and his experience in strategic planning, Zhang has played a key role in modernizing China's armed forces and strengthening civil-military relations. Critics suggest his prominence is tied as much to political reliability as to operational expertise, reflecting the Party's emphasis on loyalty within the PLA hierarchy. Nevertheless, his position grants him substantial influence over national defense policy and military modernization initiatives.

Wang Yang

Wang Yang is Chairman of the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC) and a veteran party leader with a long record in provincial governance. Known for his pragmatic and reform-oriented approach,

Wang has focused on economic development, urban planning, and consensus-building within the party. Critics contend that his influence is more symbolic than substantive in recent years, as centralization under Xi has limited the role of advisory bodies. Nonetheless, his leadership of the CPPCC allows him to shape consultative policies and represent various social and economic interests within the party system.

II. Maoists

Li Xi – PSC member, Anti-Corruption Chief

Li Xi is a Politburo Standing Committee member and head of the Central Commission for Discipline Inspection, China's feared anti-corruption body. A longtime associate of Xi, he has overseen sweeping investigations targeting both senior officials and lower cadres, presented as a "cleansing" of the Party. His campaigns recall Maoist-style rectification drives, reinforcing loyalty while removing rivals. Although he has cultivated a reputation as incorruptible, some allege that the CCDI selectively targets Xi's critics more than loyalists, fueling resentment inside the Party.

Zhang Hongliang – Maoist Professor

Zhang Hongliang is a nationalist academic and one of China's loudest Maoist voices. Teaching at Central China Normal University, he gained prominence through essays attacking privatization, globalization, and Western influence while calling for a return to egalitarian socialism. His writings circulate widely online, earning him a strong grassroots following among students and disillusioned workers. Though never part of the CCP hierarchy, he is watched closely by the state, and his critics accuse him of stirring social instability through radical rhetoric.

Han Deqiang – Maoist Economist

Han Deqiang is a fiery economics professor best known for his sharp attacks on China's market reforms. He argues that economic liberalization betrayed socialism and widened inequality, advocating a return to centralized planning and redistribution. His confrontational style and lectures have made him a symbol of grassroots leftist discontent. While popular among younger activists, Han has faced censorship and disciplinary action at universities, and some allege he exploits disillusionment for personal notoriety.

Song Tao – Head of Taiwan Affairs Office

Song Tao is a veteran diplomat currently leading the Taiwan Affairs Office, making him central to Beijing's cross-strait policy. A former head of the International Liaison Department, he has long experience managing foreign relationships on behalf of the CCP. He is regarded as a hardliner on "reunification," pressing for more aggressive stances toward Taiwan. Rumors suggest that his uncompromising positions have at times clashed with more pragmatic officials, raising questions about whether he pushes military solutions too quickly.

III. Technocrats

Zhao Leji – PSC member, NPC Chairman

Zhao Leji is Chairman of the National People's Congress and a Standing Committee member, giving him formal oversight of China's legislature. He built his career in Qinghai and Shaanxi before leading the CCP's Organization Department and later the anti-corruption body, making him a seasoned Party manager. Known for his cautious, low-profile style, Zhao is often described as a stabilizer in the leadership. However, he is seen as politically sidelined under Xi's dominance, with little space to assert independent influence.

Wang Huning – PSC member, Chief Ideologue

Wang Huning is the CCP's top theorist and a rare academic to reach the Politburo Standing Committee. Before politics, he taught international politics at Fudan University, where his critiques of Western liberalism caught Party attention. He has since shaped ideology under three leaders, crafting doctrines from "Three Represents" to "Xi Jinping Thought." While his influence is undeniable, some whisper that he is a political chameleon, serving whoever holds power rather than holding convictions of his own.

Hu Chunhua – Politburo member, sidelined reformist

Hu Chunhua was once considered a top candidate for leadership, known as one of the CCP's "Sixth Generation" leaders under Hu Jintao. He built his career in Tibet and Inner Mongolia before becoming Vice Premier, focusing on rural development and poverty reduction. Despite his technocratic reputation, Hu was excluded from the Standing Committee in 2022, a move widely seen as Xi sidelining a rival faction. Though still a Politbu-

ro member, his diminished role highlights the marginalization of reformist voices.

Ma Xingrui – Party Secretary of Xinjiang

Ma Xingrui is an aerospace engineer-turned-politician who now serves as Party Secretary of Xinjiang. Previously governor of Guangdong, he was transferred to Xinjiang in 2021 to oversee Beijing's controversial security policies in the region. Though respected as a capable technocrat, his tenure in Xinjiang has been overshadowed by international accusations of human rights abuses against Uyghurs. Critics allege that his pragmatic background makes him ill-suited for the political sensitivity of his current assignment.

Yi Gang – Former PBoC Governor

Yi Gang is an economist who served as Governor of the People's Bank of China from 2018 to 2023, shaping monetary policy during turbulent times. A trained economist with experience abroad, he was known for advocating market reforms and international engagement. Although no longer in office, he remains a respected technocratic voice in economic circles, particularly among reformists wary of political interference in finance. His reputation has been clouded by whispers that Xi viewed him as too close to Western institutions, limiting his future prospects.

Zhang Yiming

Zhang Yiming is the co-founder of ByteDance and one of China's most prominent tech entrepreneurs, credited with creating globally influential digital platforms such as TikTok. He is known for his innovation-driven management style and strategic vision in the tech and social media sectors. Critics argue that his rapid rise and global influence expose him to regulatory scrutiny and political risk, especially as the government strengthens oversight of big tech. Despite these challenges, Zhang's position as a leading tech figure gives him considerable influence over China's digital economy and content ecosystem.

IV. Other Representatives

Huang Kunming – Politburo member, Party Secretary of Guangdong

Huang Kunming is a senior CCP official and currently serves as Party Secretary of Guangdong, China's economic powerhouse province. A longtime figure in the Party's

propaganda system, he previously led the Central Propaganda Department, where he managed ideological messaging and media control. In Guangdong, Huang oversees the country's most dynamic regional economy, balancing Beijing's push for Party dominance with the demands of global trade and innovation. He is often caught between pressure from the center and the needs of coastal business elites, fueling speculation that he represents one of the few remaining bases of semi-independent provincial influence.

Shen Yiqin – State Councilor, only woman in China's cabinet

Shen Yiqin was elevated to State Councilor in 2023, making her the only woman currently serving at China's cabinet level. A native of Guizhou, she built her career in provincial leadership and gained recognition for her work on poverty alleviation and ethnic minority policy. She has presented herself as a pragmatic administrator, but critics argue her rise reflects the Party's need for gender representation more than political strength. Nevertheless, her unique position gives her influence in representing women and minorities within the CCP system, and her proximity to Xi's poverty campaigns ensures she has allies in the leadership.

Sun Chunlan – Former Vice Premier

Sun Chunlan served as Vice Premier until her retirement in 2023, overseeing health, education, and sports policy. She became one of the most visible faces of China's "zero-COVID" strategy, directing lockdowns, testing campaigns, and public health mobilization. While praised for her discipline and effectiveness, she was also criticized for her harsh enforcement and lack of compassion during the pandemic. Though formally retired, she still maintains networks within the bureaucracy and public health sector, and her legacy makes her both respected and resented inside China.

Guo Shengkun – Former head of Political and Legal Affairs Commission

Guo Shengkun is a veteran security official who led the CCP's Political and Legal Affairs Commission until 2022, making him one of the most powerful figures in charge of China's police, intelligence, and legal systems. He rose from a career in the aluminum industry and provincial leadership in Guangxi before entering national politics, where he became known for his cautious but firm style.

Though retired, his networks in the Ministry of Public Security and state security services remain influential. Some suggest these networks occasionally act as a counterbalance to the authority of Chen Yixin, Xi's current security chief, making Guo a lingering presence in China's shadow politics.

Dong Mingzhu – CEO of Gree Electric

Dong Mingzhu is one of China's most famous business leaders and chairwoman of Gree Electric, a Fortune 500 appliance giant. Rising from a saleswoman to the top of one of China's most successful companies, she is celebrated as a self-made woman in a male-dominated system. Dong has often positioned herself as a defender of Chinese innovation and state-backed industry, while openly criticizing bureaucratic inefficiency and corruption. Her high profile and outspoken personality have occasionally clashed with the Party's preference for subdued corporate leaders, leading to speculation about how much independence she truly has in navigating the state-private sector balance.

Peng Liyuan – First Lady of China

Peng Liyuan is China's First Lady and one of the country's most recognizable cultural figures. A celebrated singer in the People's Liberation Army's performing troupe, she enjoyed nationwide fame long before her marriage to Xi Jinping. Elevated to the role of cultural ambassador, Peng has represented China on the world stage, particularly in Africa and Europe, and has been deployed in domestic propaganda as the ideal image of a modern, patriotic Chinese woman. While she holds no formal political office, her position as a PLA major general and her soft-power influence make her a unique player. Some observers note her occasional prominence abroad contrasts with her careful avoidance of politics at home, where visibility is tightly managed.

Zhao Leji – PSC member, NPC Chairman

Zhao Leji is Chairman of the National People's Congress and a Standing Committee member, giving him formal oversight of China's legis

FURTHER READING

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